

6.1 The eXPerience

If you're a performance freak and couldn't care less how Windows looks, so long as it boots up in 20 seconds flat, and opens programs faster than ever before, we honestly suggest you move along to the chapter on tweaking tips. However, if you're willing to sacrifice on a little performance, and want to customise your user interface and make a personal statement, this is the right chapter for you.

Windows XP was a huge step over Windows 98 and Windows 2000, and looks wasn't the least of the reasons! As far as good-looking OSes go, before XP, Apple's Mac OS ruled the roost—there just wasn't any competition. Microsoft made sure with their XP launch that all dissenters were quietened. For the first time, users saw a fancy-looking Start Menu and Taskbar, with rounded corners and transparencies in application windows. At last, here was a Windows version that was not just enhanced for better performance and stability, but also in terms of aesthetics.

Though XP is great-looking all by itself, you can give it a makeover to better suit your style. Besides, almost everyone running Windows XP has the same looking Desktop, with only wallpapers differing.

The very first way to differentiate your desktop is to tweak a few settings.

6.2 Tweaking Visual Settings

The Start Menu

The first thing you notice about Windows XP is the changed Start Menu. The Start button itself is a vibrant green and the Taskbar is a beautiful blue. However, you don't have to be content with what Windows provides you with by default, and changing settings is as simple as right-clicking on the Taskbar!